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where, $\gamma = \frac{C_P}{C_v}$, which is the ratio between specific heat at constant pressure and specific heat at constant volume.

Differentiating equation (11.23) on both the sides, we get

$$V^{\gamma}\, dP + P\,(\gamma V^{\gamma-1}\, dV) = 0$$

$$\text{or,} \quad \gamma P = -V\frac{dp}{dV} = B_A \qquad (11.24)$$

where, B_A is the adiabatic bulk modulus of air. Now, substituting equation (11.24) in equation (11.16), the speed of sound in air is

$$v_A = \sqrt{\frac{B_A}{\rho}} = \sqrt{\frac{\gamma P}{\rho}} = \sqrt{\gamma}\, v_T \qquad (11.25)$$

Since air contains mainly, nitrogen, oxygen, hydrogen etc, (diatomic gas), we take γ = 1.47. Hence, speed of sound in air is $v_A = (\sqrt{1.4})(280 \text{ m s}^{-1}) = 331.30 \text{ m s}^{-1}$, which is very much closer to experimental data.

11.4.3 Factors affecting speed of sound in gases

Let us consider an ideal gas whose equation of state is

$$PV = n\,R\,T \qquad (11.26)$$

where, P is pressure, V is volume, T is temperature, n is number of mole and R is universal gas constant. For a given mass of a molecule, equation (11.26) can be written as

$$\frac{PV}{T} = \text{Constant} \qquad (11.27)$$

For a fixed mass m, density of the gas inversely varies with volume. i.e.,

$$\rho \propto \frac{1}{V}, \quad V = \frac{m}{\rho} \qquad (11.28)$$

Substituting equation (11.28) in equation (11.27), we get

$$\frac{P}{\rho} = cT \qquad (11.29)$$

where c is constant.

The speed of sound in air given in equation (11.25) can be written as

$$v = \sqrt{\frac{\gamma P}{\rho}} = \sqrt{\gamma c T} \qquad (11.30)$$

From the above relation we observe the following

(a) Effect of pressure :

For a fixed temperature, when the pressure varies, correspondingly density also varies such that the ratio $\left(\frac{P}{\rho}\right)$ becomes constant. This means that the speed of sound is independent of pressure for a fixed temperature. If the temperature remains same at the top and the bottom of a mountain then the speed of sound will remain same at these two points. But, in practice, the temperatures are not same at top and bottom of a mountain; hence, the speed of sound is different at different points.

(b) Effect of temperature :

Since $v \propto \sqrt{T}$,

the speed of sound varies directly to the square root of temperature in kelvin.

Let v_0 be the speed of sound at temperature at 0° C or 273 K and v be the speed of sound at any arbitrary temperature T (in kelvin), then

$$\frac{v}{v_0} = \sqrt{\frac{T}{273}} = \sqrt{\frac{273+t}{273}}$$

$$v = v_0\sqrt{1+\frac{t}{273}} \cong v_0\left(1+\frac{t}{546}\right)$$

(using binomial expansion)